



**A traditional computer game
for 2-4 players in about 30-45 minutes**

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INTRODUCTION

At the head office of Splotter-4-All Computer Services the phones just won't stop ringing: complaints galore! Everyone wants internet. Where are all the connections?

WEB is a game in which players attempt to connect as many computers as possible. More than anyone else at least. If that isn't possible by connecting more computers yourself, there are other means: Stealing computers from your neighbor, dumping uninteresting contracts on them...in WEB, everything is allowed!

Network Infrastructure

60 Network tiles (18 4-squared, 24 3-squared & 18 2-squared), 1 Central Server tile, 72 cables (18 each in player colors: yellow, black, blue & white), 4 scoring cubes (1 per player color) & scoreboard

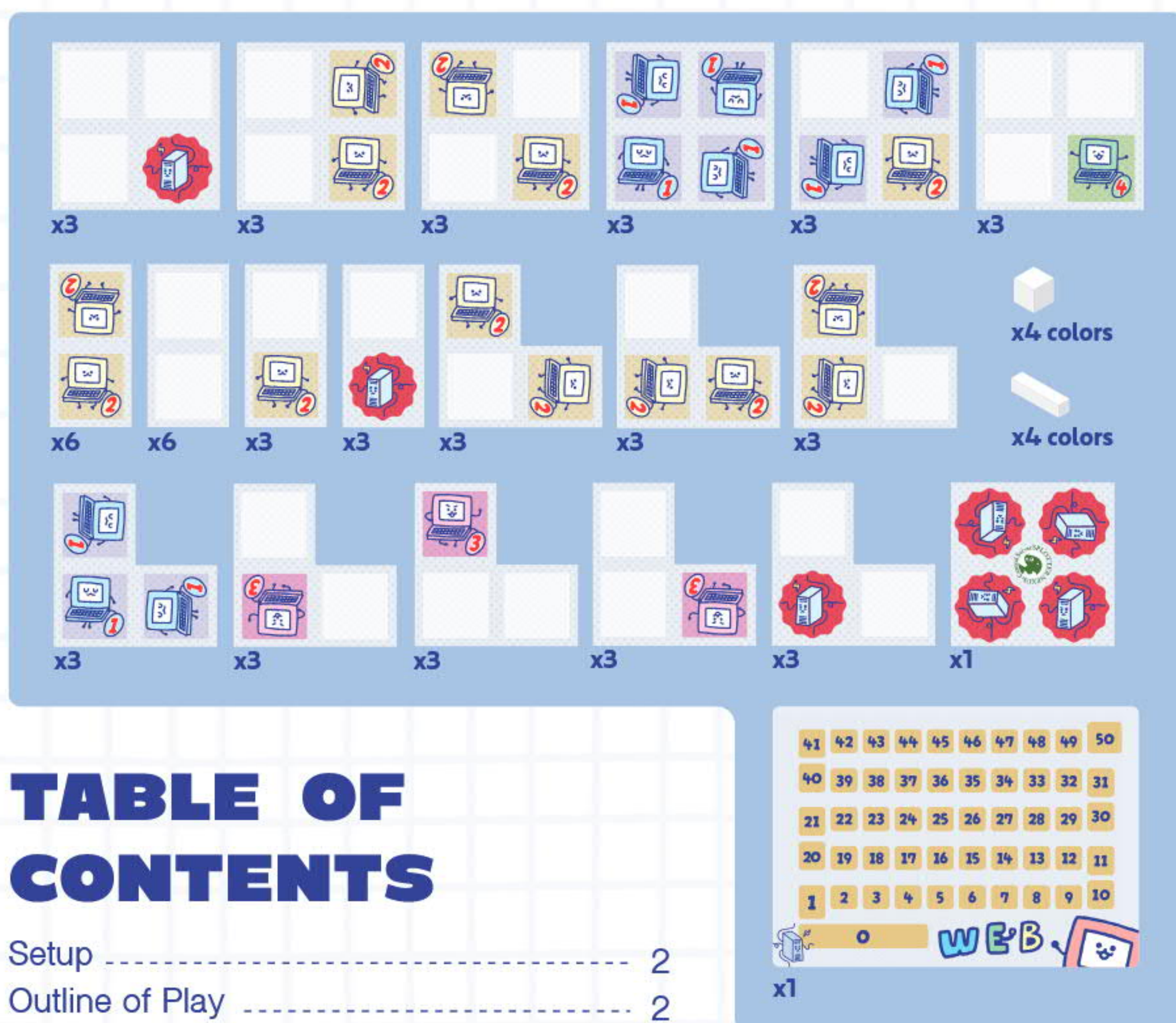


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SETUP

Place the Central Server tile in the center of the table. Sort the other tiles by shape, and shuffle each group, keeping the computers and servers face up (the side with the  is secret). Deal each player one tile of each shape.

Make six piles with the remaining tiles (computer side face up): two stacks of each shape (as equal as possible dictated by number of players). The two piles of L-shaped tiles will be slightly higher than the other four.

Each player takes all 18 cables (wooden rods) in their player color. They start the game with three in front of them, and the rest are placed aside (their *Personal Store*).

OUTLINE OF PLAY

Players take turns at playing their tiles. The player with the least total computer points across their three starting tiles starts the game. If tied, the player with the least computers goes first.

A turn consists of 1) playing a tile and 2) performing actions.

Note that tiles are not drawn automatically!

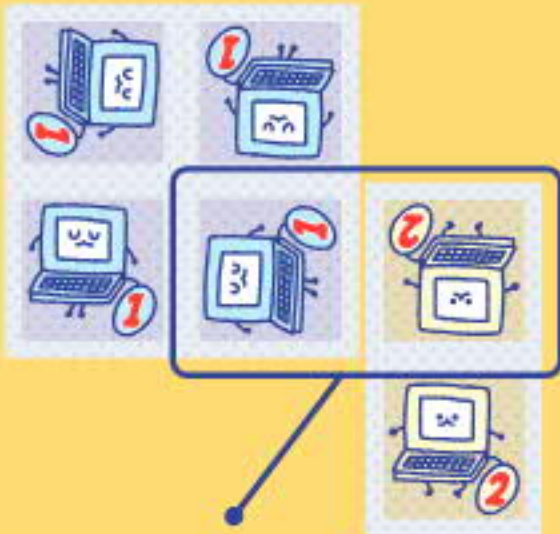
New tiles can be drawn only by performing the ‘**Draw a Single Tile**’ action.

The game ends as soon as one of the six piles of tiles runs out, or if only one of the players has any tiles left in front of them.

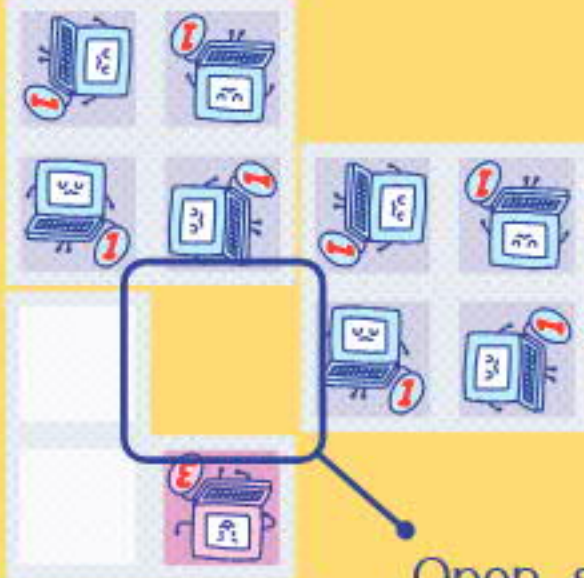
PLAYING A TILE

A single tile must be played at the beginning of a player’s turn such that at least one side of one of the squares borders on a tile that has already been placed (including the Central Server). Before placing the tile, the player must clearly state the number of  on the back of it. We also recommend showing them.

Leaving open space between tiles is permitted. During the game, open space the size of a single square may come to exist. As no tile can fit inside this space, they are considered equivalent to blank squares on tiles.



At least one full edge of one of the squares on a tile being placed must border another square on a tile that has already been placed.



Open spaces the size of a single square are treated the same as blank spaces on tiles.

PERFORMING ACTIONS

The number of the  on the tile played determines the number of actions a player may perform. There are three types of actions. A player may choose the order in which they perform their actions. And may take the same action multiple times.

 **Draw a Single Tile**

 **Buy 3 Cables from Personal Store**

 **Place a Single Cable**

DRAW A SINGLE TILE

A player who selects this action may draw the top tile of any of the six piles. They may only inspect the face-up side showing the computers and servers (i.e. they may not look at the back showing the  !)

If this causes a pile to be exhausted, the game ends immediately.

BUY 3 CABLES FROM PERSONAL STORE

Cables are always bought three at a time from a player's Personal Store, and are then placed on the table in front of them. A player cannot buy more cables than are available in their store. Buying does not require spending anything.

PLACE A SINGLE CABLE

A cable is placed orthogonally between the centers of two squares. Diagonal connections are not allowed. A cable must connect to an existing network (series of connected cables) of the same color or directly to a server. All cables thus connect directly or indirectly to a server. If indirectly, the link is made by cables all of the same color.

***Note** that some of the tiles contain extra servers. Players can play these anywhere on the map, and are then accessible to all players. Four cables can start from such a server, one at each side.*

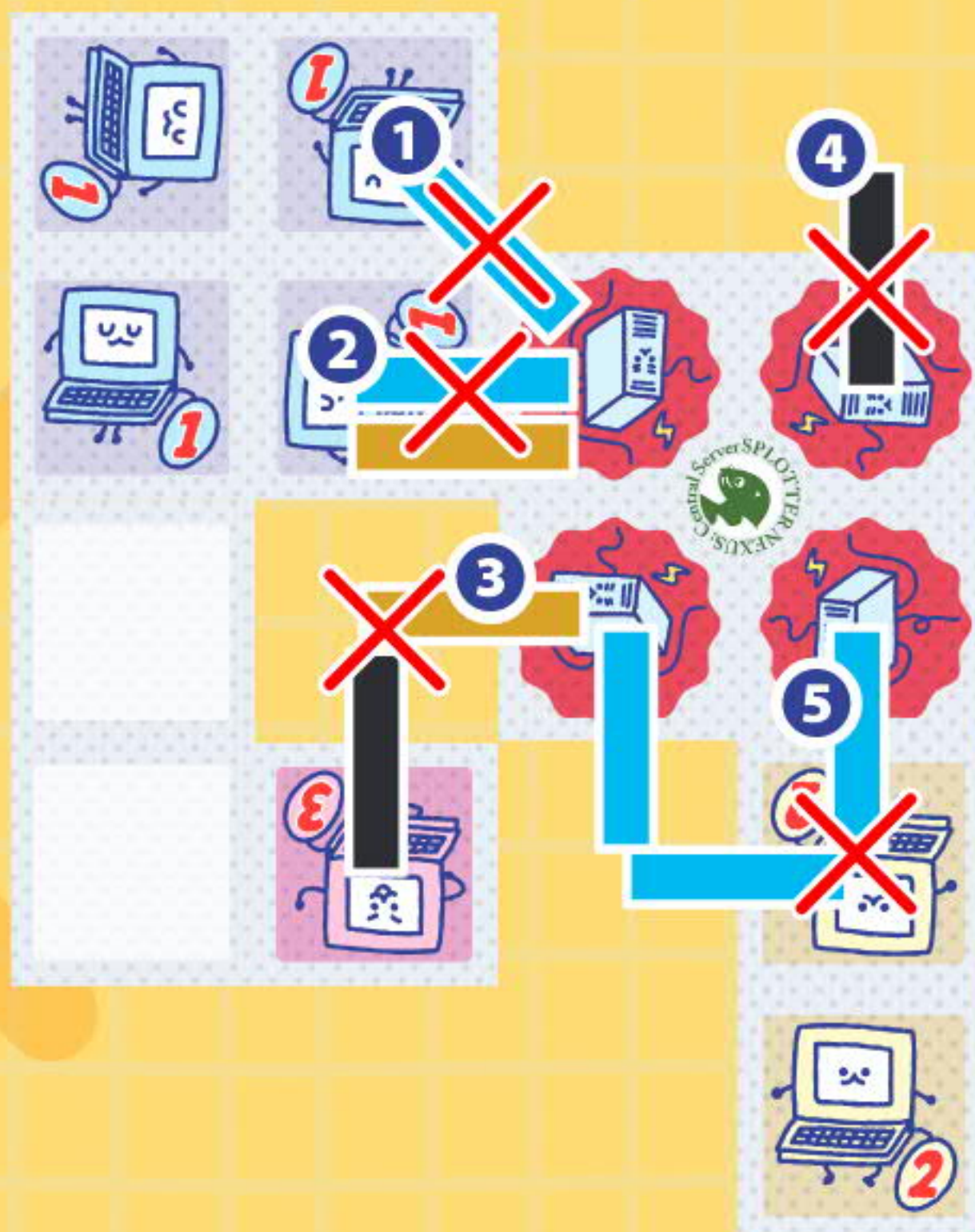
A blank square on a tile can be connected in four directions. Cables may form junctions. Cables of different players may cross. They may also curve away from each other. It is not allowed to place cables parallel to one another: only one cable may cross any border of a square.

A square containing a computer is a terminus i.e. it may only be connected from one side. A cable connecting a computer thus ends there, and cannot be connected to another square. Connecting a computer to a server yields the number of points indicated next to the computer.

It is not permitted to let a cable run off a tile onto the table, unless there is an empty, single space too small for a tile to fit inside. Such an area is treated the same as a blank tile square.

Illegal Connections

- ❶ Diagonal connection
- ❷ Parallel connection
- ❸ Connected to a different color
- ❹ Cable going off tile
- ❺ Computer connected on two sides



Legal Connections

- A. Connected to same color, branching off
- B. Connected directly to server
- C. Servers can be connected from all 4 sides by any player(s).
- D. Different player links crossing perpendicularly
- E. Computer connected to one side
- F. Cable can remain "hanging" on a single blank square or open space

GAME END & SCORING

The game ends immediately as soon as one of the six piles of tiles is exhausted.

- ★ **Each player counts the number of points next to the computers they have connected.**
- ★ **Deduct one point for each tile the player still holds.**
- ★ **Whoever scores the most points wins the game.**

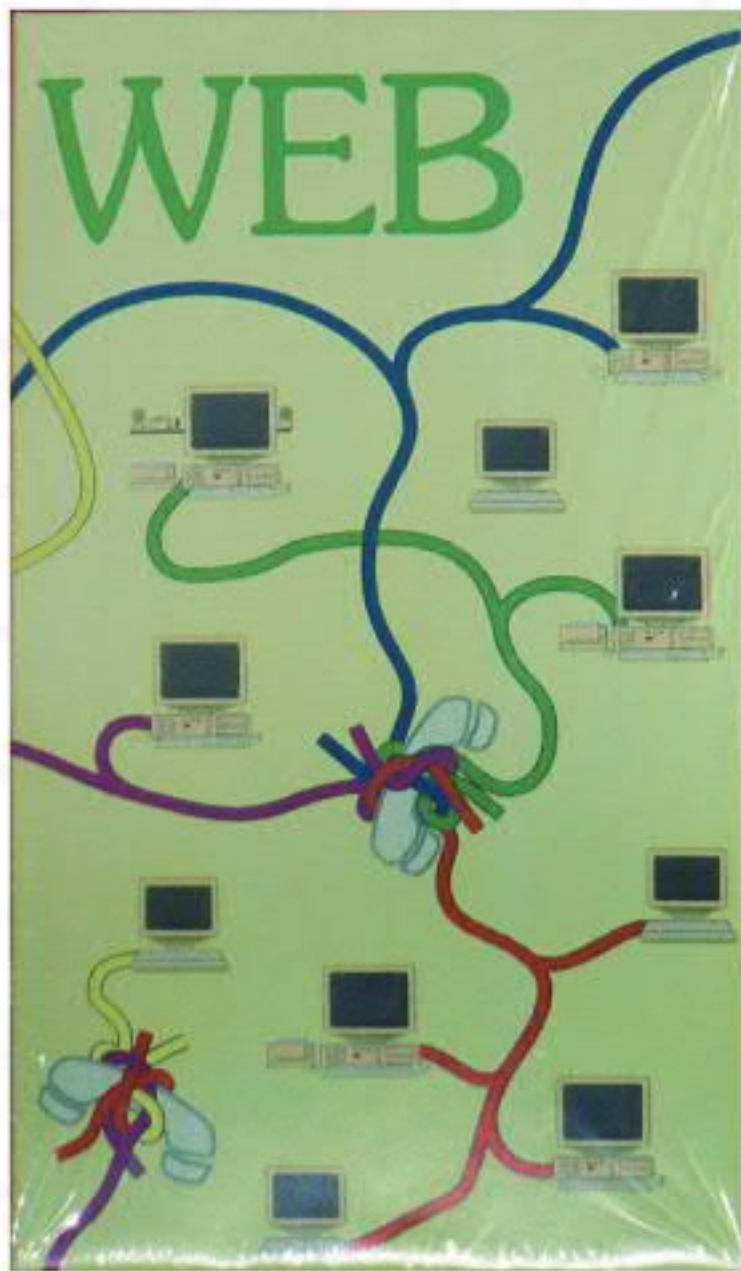
It is possible that a player runs out of tiles before the game ends i.e. has no tile to lay at the beginning of their turn. If this happens, the player is no longer permitted to take turns and their score will remain unchanged until the end of the game. If there is only one player left who has any tiles, the game ends immediately. Points are counted as usual.

ADVANCED GAME (OFFICIAL)

To make the game more difficult, place objects on the table before starting the game (e.g. some coins or a cellphone). Players are not allowed to place tiles over these obstacles. The rest of the game stays the same, but playing with this rule yields many more strategic options!

VARIANT RULES (UNOFFICIAL)

1. To offset some of the randomness of the players' starting tiles, remove all Server tiles when dealing out the initial three tiles to players.
2. Players were required to calculate and keep track of player scores in their heads throughout the game in the original rules. We believe this only adds cognitive load without any strategic benefit so we have included an optional scoreboard and player cubes to keep track during the game. We hope this will enable players to better concentrate on strategy.



WEB was one of the original designs that Splotter Spellen brought to their first Essen Spiel, and the first co-design with Joris and Jeroen.

“Yeah, so the original story for WEB was that Jeroen and I wanted to make a game for the electricity company in the Netherlands.” The electric company was hosting a game design contest at the time so the two fledgeling designers were originally going to make a game about connecting houses to the electricity network and other utilities (long before Power Grid). But they never ended up sending their design in. “And then we decided that connecting to the internet was a more up-to-date idea than this, more modern. That may even have been Herman's idea to put the internet in. It might have been driven by graphics.”

“And that was a very annoying game,” noted Jeroen. Because the company was still hand-making every copy of their games at this stage, the L-shaped tiles in WEB were time consuming. The square and rectangular tiles could very easily be cut with a cutting machine, which was the very first thing they bought as a company, but it could only make straight cuts. So the L-shaped tiles had to be done with an X-acto knife and ruler. Joris chimed in, “And that's a ridiculous amount of work. I was in favor of kicking out the corners so that it would be easier to actually make the game. But [Jeroen] thought it would be a worse game so we had corners to cut. We actually cut a lot of corners literally on the trade fair floor. People would ask for a game, and we'd tell them to please come back in one hour so we could cut them.”

Taken from excerpts of an interview with Joris Wiersinga and Jeroen Doumen hosted by Dean Brandt over Zoom on January 16, 2025.

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Gathering for Splotter boardgame fans.

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